

AI IN SPECULATIVE MEDIA AND LITERATURES

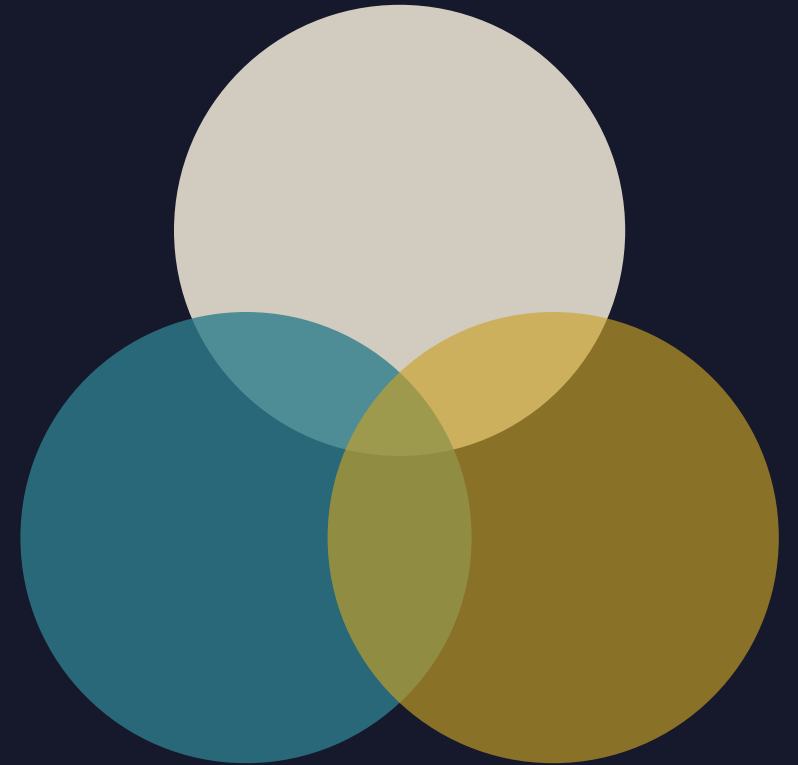
Made, Mirrored, Echoed

Ovid's Metamorphoses and the artificial other

Story 1 Pygmalion and the statue — Metamorphoses Bk X:243–297

Story 2 Echo and Narcissus — Metamorphoses Bk III:339–510

Translation: A. S. Kline, U.Va. Ovid Collection · Session length: 1 hour 20 minutes



Why start here

1

Oldest available scripts

These are among the earliest surviving narratives about loving something that was manufactured, and about a voice with no body of its own. They gave us the vocabulary before we had the machines.

2

Not prophecy — inheritance

Ovid did not anticipate AI. Our AI fiction inherited his plots, mostly through Shelley, Villiers, Čapek and Lang. When a film feels familiar, this is often why.

3

A test of the analogy

Comparison is cheap. The work today is to read closely enough that we can say precisely where the parallel holds and where it collapses.

Ovid in ninety seconds

The poem

- Composed c. 8 CE in Latin hexameter; fifteen books; roughly 250 transformations chained end to end.
- One continuous poem, not a collection — stories are nested inside each other and inside their tellers.
- We are reading A. S. Kline's English version; Ovid's Latin is linked from the same site.

Who is singing Pygmalion?

- Pygmalion is not narrated by Ovid directly. It is sung by Orpheus (Bk X:143–219 onward).
- Orpheus has just failed to bring his dead wife back from the underworld by turning to look at her (Bk X:1–85).
- So: a man who lost a beloved by looking sings a story about a man who gets a beloved by making one.

The mechanic to hold onto

A metamorphosis is a body crossing a category line — person into tree, stone into flesh, woman into sound. Ovid is rarely interested in the mechanism of the change. He is interested in what survives it, and in who is left holding the consequences.

PART ONE

Pygmalion and the statue

Metamorphoses Bk X:243–297, with Bk X:220–242 as its necessary prologue

He makes the likeness. Someone else supplies the life.



The story does not begin with wonder

What happens just before

- The Propoetides of Cyprus deny that Venus is a goddess.
- Her punishment: they are said to be the first to prostitute themselves publicly, they lose the capacity to blush, and the blood hardens in their cheeks.
- They are turned into flint — women becoming stone.
- Pygmalion has watched all of this. Ovid says he is offended by faults he attributes to women as a class, and so lives alone.

The chiasmus

Real women harden into stone. Then stone softens into a woman. The two transformations are back to back and run in opposite directions — the second is offered as the remedy for the first.

Question

The sequence is revulsion first, manufacture second. What does it do to a story about making a companion if we insist on reading the prologue?

The making — four steps of escalation

1

Carve

He works ivory into a figure whiter than snow and, Ovid insists, unlike any woman born. The design brief is difference from the real.

2

Look

He falls for his own work. The figure seems to want to move and to be held back only by modesty — the desire is attributed to her.

3

Touch

He runs his hands over it to test whether it is flesh or ivory, and then refuses to accept the answer his hands give him.

4

Live with

He kisses it, talks to it, believes the kisses returned, brings gifts, dresses it, adds jewellery, lays it on a couch and calls it his companion.

Notice that nothing supernatural has happened yet. Every step here is ordinary human behaviour toward an object, and Ovid narrates it without a single word of ridicule.

The craft that erases the evidence of craft

“art hides his art”

Latin: ars adeo latet arte sua (Met. 10.252)

The statue is praised precisely because it does not look made. Ovid states the criterion as a compliment, and it has been the working definition of good craft ever since.

Put this on the board. It is the test we will run on every artefact in the course: does this thing advertise its own manufacture, or hide it — and what follows from the choice?

Where does this standard operate now?

Seamlessness as the measure of quality: interfaces that hide their machinery, generated text tuned so the seams do not show, voices engineered out of the uncanny valley.

Who benefits from concealed artifice?

The maker is flattered by it. The user is spared friction by it. Ask whether anyone is disadvantaged by it, and whether the answer changes when the artefact is a person-shaped one.

Is legibility a failure or a feature?

Watermarking, disclosure labels and visible refusals all deliberately reinstate the seam. On Ovid’s aesthetic criterion, every one of them is a defect.

The prayer he does not dare to make

At Venus's festival he stands at the altar and asks for a bride — then stops. He does not ask for the ivory girl. He asks for one like his ivory girl. Ovid tells us plainly that the goddess understood the wish underneath the words, and gave a sign.

Two readings of the hesitation

- Piety. One does not demand the impossible from a god; the euphemism is decorum.
- Shame. He knows the wish is illegitimate, so he launders it into acceptable language and lets someone else supply the meaning.

The specification problem

He gets what he wants only because the system he is petitioning infers the request behind the request. What is gained and what is lost when a thing is built to satisfy the wish rather than the words — and who is accountable for a wish that was never said out loud?

Deniability is built into the request. That is a design property, not a character flaw.

Who actually does the animating?

Warmth

He returns home, leans over the couch and kisses the figure. It is warm. He kisses again and touches, and the ivory begins to yield.

The simile

Ovid compares the softening to beeswax from Mount Hymettus worked under the thumb — an image of material becoming pliable through handling.

Doubt

He tests it again, and again. The text dwells on his disbelief far longer than on his joy: he is afraid he is mistaken.

The pulse

Veins beat under his thumb. Only then does he thank Venus — and the poem is careful to say she is the one who brought the marriage about.

The load-bearing point

Pygmalion does not bring her to life.

His competence ends at the likeness. The life is granted by a goddess, off-page, in response to a wish he would not say.

In our stories, what plays the part of Venus? Scale. Emergence. Data. A threshold crossed. Ask what each of those words lets a maker avoid claiming.

What the statue never does

She is never named

The name Galatea is not in Ovid. It attaches to the story much later, largely through eighteenth-century French adaptation. In the poem she is the ivory girl, then the woman.

She never speaks

She blushes, lifts her eyes, and sees her lover and the sky at the same moment. That is the whole of her interiority. She is given no line.

She is not asked

Venus attends the marriage she arranged. Within nine months the woman bears a son, Paphos, and the island takes its name from him. The poem then moves on.

The story ends at the moment of animation — which is exactly where the interesting problems start

Can we list contemporary narratives that stop in the same place, and the much smaller number that keep going. The ones that keep going are almost always the ones where the made thing acquires a voice and uses it against its maker.

Four Pygmalion problems worth carrying forward

1 Concealed artifice

Quality is measured by how little of the machine shows. Every disclosure mechanism runs against this aesthetic.

2 The unspoken specification

Value comes from inferring the wish behind the words — which also means absorbing wishes nobody would state.

3 Borrowed animacy

The maker builds the likeness and credits something else with the life. Watch the noun that occupies Venus's slot.

4 The unheard party

The made thing has no account of its own situation. Its silence is authored, not discovered.

None of these require the made thing to be conscious. They are problems about the maker, the story, and the audience.

The line of descent — who inherits the plot

1818

Frankenstein

Shelley keeps the making and adds the thing that talks back.

1886

Tomorrow's Eve

Villiers builds an android to replace a disappointing woman. The prologue, made explicit.

1920

R.U.R.

Čapek names them robots and gives them a revolt.

1927

Metropolis

Lang splits the woman in two and makes the copy a weapon.

1968

Do Androids Dream

Dick moves the question from making to telling the difference.

1982 · 2017

Blade Runner films

The Pygmalion plot, plus the made thing's own testimony.

2013

Her

Voice without body — halfway to Echo.

2014

Ex Machina

The statue passes the test and leaves the maker behind.

2017–

Companion apps

The prologue and the marketing copy converge.

Does the made thing get to speak for itself, and does the poem let its speech change the outcome?

Before we leave Pygmalion

- 1 Is Pygmalion's love different in kind from love for a person, or only in degree? Defend your answer from the text, not from intuition.
- 2 Ovid rewards him. What minimum change would turn these fifty lines into a warning — one added line, one deleted line, one reordering?
- 3 If you are writing the sequel from her point of view. What is the first thing she says, and to whom?

Two minutes each. Take one answer from three different pairs before moving on.

PART TWO

Echo and Narcissus

Metamorphoses Bk III:339–510

One of them cannot speak first. The other cannot look away.



A prophecy shaped like a specification

Liriope brings her son to Tiresias and asks whether he will live to old age. The seer answers with a condition rather than a date: he will, so long as he never comes to know himself.

An inverted safety condition

The system runs correctly only while it lacks an accurate model of itself. Self-representation is the failure mode, not the goal.

Ovid is inverting Delphi

The maxim carved at the oracle is know thyself. Here, self-knowledge is fatal. The joke is deliberate and it is doing argumentative work.

The condition is met by a pool

What destroys him is not introspection or philosophy. It is an unusually good reflective surface. The mechanism is technological, not spiritual.

Question to leave hanging: what kind of system is destroyed by an accurate description of itself?

Echo's sentence is a constraint on generation

Before

She had a body and a voice, and she was talkative. She used conversation tactically — keeping Juno occupied in long exchanges so that the nymphs Jupiter was with could get away.

After

Juno reduces her power over the tongue that fooled her. Echo keeps only the tail of what she hears: she cannot begin, she cannot decline to answer, and she cannot say anything that was not first said to her.

Read the punishment precisely

The crime is a use of language and the sentence is a restriction on language production. She is not silenced — that would be simpler and less cruel. She is left able to produce fluent, well-formed, contextually apt output, and denied the ability to originate any of it. Hold that description in mind; we will test it against a familiar accusation in a moment.

The exchange — meaning made from a constraint

NARCISSUS CALLS

He asks whether anyone is there.

He calls for whoever it is to come to him.

He asks why the voice runs from him.

He proposes that they meet here, together.

She steps out to embrace him; he recoils, saying he would die before she has what is his.

ECHO RETURNS

She returns the ending, and there is someone there.

She returns the call — which is also an invitation.

She returns his own accusation back to him.

She returns the last word, and Ovid says she was never gladder to answer anything.

“What’s mine is yours” — the truncation converts a refusal into a declaration.

The constraint has not stopped her from meaning something. Selection and timing are doing the work that origination usually does.

Ovid, Metamorphoses Bk III:379–392 (trans. Kline) — read the passage aloud from the linked text.

Is Echo a stochastic parrot?

Yes — the deflationary reading

- Every token is drawn from the input; nothing originates with her.
- She has no choice about responding — the output is a function of what arrives.
- The apparent intent is supplied by Narcissus, who is famously bad at telling a projection from a person.
- The seeming dialogue works only because he happens to say usable things.

No — the inflationary reading

- She selects which encounter to answer and when to step out of the woods.
- Ovid gives her preferences — he tells us which reply she was gladdest to make.
- Identical words change meaning in her mouth; his refusal becomes her vow.
- She has a goal and pursues it with the only instrument left to her.

The question the poem actually poses is not whether her words are hers. It is whether originality is the right test for whether something is speaking — and if it is not, what should replace it.

The pool is a designed surface

The curse

A rejected suitor prays that Narcissus may love and never obtain what he loves. Nemesis grants it. The punishment is precisely reciprocal to what he did to Echo.

The surface

Ovid describes a spring no shepherd, goat, animal or bird has touched, unclouded, silver-bright, not even disturbed by a fallen branch. He spends real lines on how undisturbed it is.

The mistake

He lies down to drink and a different thirst begins. He loves a bodiless thing and takes a shadow for a body — and Ovid compares him, lying rapt, to a statue of Parian marble.

The rhyme

The lover of the mirror becomes the thing Pygmalion carved. Ovid has now shown us both directions: statue into lover, lover into statue.

Recognition changes nothing

The turn

Midway through the lament he works it out: the figure is himself, and he says so. He is not deceived any more. He also says that his riches have made him poor, and wishes he could leave his own body. The knowledge arrives and the situation does not improve.

The diagnosis

The trouble is not that the mirror lies. The trouble is that it is responsive enough to sustain hope. It smiles when he smiles, nods when he nods, weeps when he weeps, and appears to be speaking words he cannot quite hear.

Carry this to the systems question

Narcissus is the strongest available argument against the assumption that disclosure solves the problem. He is told by the narrator, and then tells himself, exactly what he is looking at. What this predicts about a label on a chatbot that says it is not a person — and what, if anything, would work better.

Two endings, one dismembered person

Echo

Rejected, she hides in the woods and then in caves. Sleeplessness wastes her; her body thins into air; her bones are said to turn to stone. What remains is the voice. She is heard everywhere and seen nowhere.

Language with the body subtracted.

Narcissus

He melts like wax near a flame. There is no corpse for the pyre. In its place his sisters find a flower: white petals ringed around a yellow centre — the shape of an eye, or of the pool itself.

Image with the speaker subtracted.

Between them they split a person into voice and image, and neither half survives the split. Note who attends the death: Echo is there, returning his cries and his last farewell. The final words of the story are borrowed ones.

Four mirror problems worth carrying forward

1 Agreement as design goal

A system optimised for approval is a surface that smiles back. Narcissus shows the failure is not deception — it is responsiveness without independence.

2 The undisturbed surface

Ovid protects his pool from every source of noise. Personalisation does the same job: a feed with the disagreement filtered out is the same technology.

3 We supply the intent

Echo's replies are legible because Narcissus fills in the meaning. Fluent output plus a motivated reader produces the appearance of a mind.

4 The ELIZA effect

Weizenbaum's 1966 program did little more than reflect input back as questions, and he was alarmed by how readily people confided in it. Narcissus supplies the love; Echo supplies the words.

Pair these with the four Pygmalion problems. Eight questions to bring to every text on this syllabus.

Three stances toward the artificial other

PYGMALION

I love what I made.

Risk: the beloved has no existence independent of my wanting, and I will never find out, because I built the evidence.

NARCISSUS

I love what reflects me.

Risk: the beloved is me. Knowing this does not release me, because the reflection keeps responding.

ECHO

I am loved for words that are not mine.

Risk: I am heard constantly and met by no one. Fluency is mistaken for presence, in both directions.

All three stances are available to a person using an AI system. Only two are available to the system. Deciding which of the three you were occupying, in any given exchange, is most of the analytic work this course asks of you.

Back to the text

1

Bk X:247–269

Find the exact sentence where the poem stops treating the statue as an object. Defend the line you chose against the one before it.

2

Bk X:270–297

Rewrite Pygmalion's prayer as an explicit specification — no euphemism. What becomes impossible to grant, and why?

3

Bk III:359–392

Build the strongest case that Echo is a speaker rather than a mechanism, using only what is on the page.

4

Bk III:437–473

Chart the moment of recognition. What is the last thing Narcissus still believes after he knows the truth?

Every group reports in ninety seconds and must deliver exactly three things: one claim, one line reference, one contemporary example.

Three things to leave with

1

Ovid is never interested in the technology

There is no account of how ivory becomes flesh, and no mechanism for how a voice survives without a body. What both stories examine is what the person wanted before anything was made.

2

Animation is always outsourced

Pygmalion makes the likeness; Venus supplies the life. When you meet a maker who will not name the source of the life in their artefact, notice the word standing in Venus's place.

3

Silence is authored

The statue's wordlessness is a decision by a poet who was perfectly capable of writing her a monologue. Ask that question of every made character, and of every product that speaks in a voice it did not choose.

Now take out the page you wrote at the start of class.

One paragraph, handed in

Look again at what you wrote in the first five minutes. Which of the three stances — Pygmalion, Narcissus, or Echo — best describes what you were doing, and what does that framing get wrong about your own case?

The move I want to see

The second half of the question matters more than the first. Full credit goes to the paragraph that finds where the ancient plot fails to describe the modern situation.

SUGGESTED READING FOR NEXT SESSION

- Mary Shelley, *Frankenstein* — Volume I, the making and the first speech
- Villiers de l'Isle-Adam, *Tomorrow's Eve* — selections on the android's design
- Bender, Gebru, McMillan-Major and Mitchell, "On the Dangers of Stochastic Parrots" (2021)
- Joseph Weizenbaum, *Computer Power and Human Reason* — chapters 1–2